

To Lytton Strachey

Saturday morning, 12 o'clock [May 14th, 1921] The Mill House, Tidmarsh

My dearest Lytton, There is a great deal to say and I feel very incompetent to write it today. Last night I composed a great many letters to you, almost till three in the morning. I then wrote an imaginary letter and bared my very soul to you. This morning I don't feel so intimate. *You* mayn't value my pent up feelings and a tearful letter. *I* rather object to them not being properly received and left about. Well there was more of a crisis than I thought when I wrote to you on Thursday. Ralph had one of his break downs and completely collapsed. He threw himself in the Woolves' arms and asked their sympathy and advice. Leonard and Virginia both said it was hopeless for him to go on as he was, that he must either marry me, or leave me completely. He came down to Reading yesterday and met me at the Coffee tea shop. He looked dreadfully ill and his mouth twitched. I'd really made my mind up some time ago that if it came to the ultimate point, I would give in. Only typically I preferred to defer it indefinitely and avoid it if possible. You see I knew there was nothing really to hope for from you—Well ever since the beginning. Then Alix told me last spring what you told James. That you were slightly terrified of my becoming dependent on you, and a permanent limpet and other things. I didn't tell you, because after all, it is no use having scenes. But you must know Ralph repeated every word you once told him in bed; that night when we were all three together. The next day we went for a walk on the Swindon downs. Perhaps you remember. I shall never forget that spot of ground, just outside Chisledon, at the foot of the downs, when he repeated every word you had said. He told me of course because he was jealous and wanted to hurt me. But it altered things, because ever after that I had a terror of being physically on your nerves and revolting you. I never came again to your bedroom. Why am I raking all this up now? Only to tell you that all these years I have known all along that my life with you was limited. I could never hope for it to become permanent. After all Lytton, you are the only person who I have ever had an all absorbing passion for. I shall never have another. I couldn't now. I had one of the most self abasing loves that a person can have. You could throw me into transports of happiness and dash me into deluges of tears and despair, all by a few words. But these aren't reproaches. For after all it's getting

on for 6 years since I first met you at Asheham; and that's a long time to be happy. And I know we shall always be friends now until I die. Of course these years of Tidmarsh when we were quite alone will always be the happiest I ever spent. And I've such a store of good things which I've saved up, that I feel I could never be lonely again now. Still it's too much of a strain to be quite alone here waiting to see you or craning my nose and eyes out of the top window at 41 Gordon Square to see if you are coming down the street, when I know we'll be better friends, if you aren't haunted by the idea that I am sitting depressed in some corner of the world waiting for your footstep. It's slightly mythical of course. I can pull myself together if I want to and I am more aware than you think, the moment I am getting on your nerves and when I am not wanted. I saw the relief you felt at Ralph taking me away, so to speak, off your hands. I think he'll make me happier, than I should be entirely by myself and it certainly prevents me becoming morbid about you. And as Ralph said last night you'll never leave us. Because in spite of our dullnesses, nobody loves you nearly as much as we do. So in the café in that vile city of Reading, I said I'd marry him. And now he's written to his father and told him. After all I don't believe it will make much difference and to see him so happy is a rather definite thing. I'd probably never marry anyone else and I doubt if a kinder creature exists on this earth. Last night in bed he told me everything Virginia and Leonard had told him. Again a conversation you had with them was repeated to me. Ralph was so happy he didn't hear me gasp and as it was dark he didn't see the tears run down my cheeks. Virginia told him that you had told them you didn't intend to come to Tidmarsh much after Italy and you were nervous lest I'd feel I had a sort of claim on you if I lived with [you] for a long time, ten years and that they all wondered how you could have stood me so long and how on earth we lived together alone here, as I didn't understand a word of literature and we had nothing in common intellectually or physically. That was wrong. For nobody I think could have loved the Ballades, Donne, and Macaulay's Essays and best of all, Lytton's Essays, as much as I. Virginia then told him that she thought I was still in love with you. Ralph asked me if I was. I said I didn't think perhaps I was as much as I used to be. So now I shall never tell *you* I do care again. It goes after today somewhere deep down inside me and I'll not resurrect it to hurt either, you, or Ralph. Never again. He knows I am not in love with him. But he feels my affections are great enough to make him happy if I live with him. I cried last night Lytton, whilst he slept by my side sleeping happily. I cried to

think of a savage cynical fate which had made it impossible for my love ever to be used by you. You never knew, or never will know the very big and devastating love I had for you. How I adored every hair, every curl on your beard. How I devoured you whilst you read to me at night. How I loved the smell of your face in your sponge.¹ Then the ivory skin on your hands, your voice, and your hat when I saw it coming along the top of the garden wall from my window. Say you will remember it, that it wasn't all lost and that you'll forgive me for this out burst, and always be my friend. Just thinking of you now makes me cry so I can't see this paper, and yet so happy that the next moment I am calm. I shall be with you in Italy in two weeks, how lovely that will be. And this summer we shall all be very happy together. Please never show this letter to anyone. Ralph is such a dear, I don't feel I'll ever regret marrying him. Though I never will change my maiden name that I have kept so long—so you mayn't ever call me anything but Carrington.

I am not going to tell my mother till the day before, so she can't make a fuss, or come up to London. I think we'll probably get united by Saint Pancras next Saturday and then drift over to Paris and see Valentine [Dobrée]. If my Fiend comes on I'll linger there for 2 days and then Italie. I've suggested Mousie and her Dan coming here for the month. And I hope I'll coerce them into it. Then we won't have to worry about the garden and the dampnesses. Nick and Barbara are still here, and this weekend Saxon, and Alan [MacIver] and Michael [Davies] come this evening. We'll pay off all the books before we leave. Now I must leave you, and paint the other side of the grey hound.²

Later.

Nick has just mown the lawn and it is now as smooth and short as a field of green plush.

All the ducks and chickens survive and Ralph spends his time lying in the sun on the lawn trying to persuade them to swim in a pan of water. I thought you had been clever to escape the thunder storms and rains, but today the heat is more wonderful than anything in your land of the Romans. Saxon is an extraordinary character!! I am telling no one what I've told you. It will remain a confession to a priest in a box in an Italian church. I saw in a London Group catalogue a picture by Walter Taylor called 'Reading Lytton Strachey's Victoria'—such is fame. I shall do a

¹ In an earlier letter she had asked him to leave it behind.

² Carrington was painting an inn sign for the Greyhound. See letter to Noel Carrington of July 15th, 1921, p. 188.

still life of a dozen Victoria's arranged in a phalanx for the next London Group. My dear I am sorry to leave you. I'll write again tomorrow. It's such a comfort having you to talk to.

My love for a dear one

Yr CARRINGTON

3 o'ck Saturday,

PS I've just read this letter again. You mustn't think I was hurt by hearing what you said to Virginia and Leonard and *that* made me cry. For I'd faced that long ago with Alix in the first years of my love for you. You gave me a much longer life than I ever deserved or hoped for and I love you for it terribly. I only cried last night at realising I never could have my Moon, that some times I must pain you, and often bore you. You who I would have given the world to have made happier than any person could be, to give you all you wanted. But dearest, this isn't a break in our affections. I'll always care as much, only now it will never burden you and we'll never discuss it again, as there will be nothing to discuss. I see I've told you very little of what I feel. But I keep on crying, if I stop and think about you. Outside the sun is baking and they all chatter, and laugh. It's cynical, this world in its opposites. Once you said to me, that Wednesday afternoon in the sitting room, you loved me as a friend. Could you tell it to me again?

Yrs CARRINGTON

To Lytton Strachey

Thursday, May 19th, 1921 Driftway, Middle Wallop, Stockbridge, Hants

Dearest Lytton, I am staying down here for two days before we whisk over to Paris. My mother bore the shock very well, and is fortunately making no fuss over it. So little fuss indeed one is apt to think perhaps she has known all along my wicked ways! She is mercifully not coming up to London which is a great relief. Dear, I've had it on my conscience that I wrote you rather a horrid letter last Sunday from Tidmarsh, but I was rather 'beside' myself, as they say. I hardly saw, or knew what I was writing. Now I am quite happy again and calm and I love my Lytton. Ralph is such a dear and somehow so childishly happy that I don't feel it's a plunge in any direction. In fact I suspect it will make practically no difference. Ralph is coming down here today to be inspected. Then we'll glide off tomorrow to London, have a joy day looking at Max's